

FIELD OF VISION SHARDA UGRA

Stick Check Artists



One of the cleverest adverts in the Tourism Department's Incredible India campaign featured in extreme close up the face of a Bengal tiger, glowing eyes and all. The words below the arresting photograph read, "Not all Indians are polite, hospitable and vegetarian". If Ric Charlesworth ever came across that ad, it's unlikely he would even crack a smile.

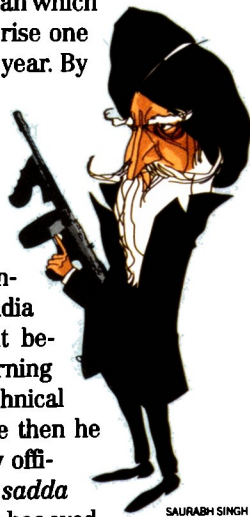
The man regarded as a modern hockey guru has spent the last few months discovering the incredible Indian Hockey Federation (IHF) and the other side of those posters. Though holding something against India on the basis of the IHF would be like nursing a grudge against Italy just because it happens to have a mafia.

Everyone in hockey knows that Charlesworth has been itching to work in India for a while now. Not for the pure joy of interacting with K.P.S. 'Capone' Gill or his consiglieri K. Jothikumaran, but just getting his teeth into what is the most fertile but rocky terrain in the business.

Four years ago in his earliest discussions with the IHF, Charlesworth presented a plan which he promised would have India rise one rung up the world ladder every year. By Beijing 2008, the Indians would, he was dead sure, be semi-final contenders. Looks like a mighty fine plan today, doesn't it?

Then, Charlesworth's services were declared to be too expensive. He was finally brought to India in 2007 through an agreement between the FIH, the sport's governing body, and the government as 'technical director' of Indian hockey. Since then he has been studiously sidelined by officials and bureaucrats loyal to *sadda* Capone. Coach Joaquim Carvalho has eyed Charlesworth as if he were one of those biased umpires he has gone on about recently. Stranded in Australia without a ticket to the Santiago qualifiers, Charlesworth was summoned to Delhi from Perth after India's exit from the Olympics to ostensibly 'define his role'. In another pointed snub, he was put up at the shadiest, dodgiest hotel the IHF could find (and they can find a few, ask the players).

It is not as if Charlesworth's merit is being challenged. It is actually being disregarded. The Australian is being denied the chance to even fail. It is a sign of the greatest insecurity. The Indian hockey establishment has tried everything for the past two decades and failed. After Chile, it is due a major rethink and some humility. Maybe Charlesworth is not the man for India, but at least we need to find out. Or is it possible that the IHF and some ex-Olympian-windbags fear that he might just be?



Justice at Last

DELHI It was a trial that involved four judges and 209 witnesses—of which 51 turned hostile—but that didn't come in the way of justice. On March 18, suspended Haryana cadre IPS officer R.K. Sharma and three others were found guilty in the Shivani Bhatnagar murder case. Bhatnagar, a journalist, was found murdered in her east Delhi apartment on January 23, 1999. The sessions court held Sharma and three others guilty of hatching the

conspiracy to kill Bhatnagar, who had allegedly threatened to expose his supposed involvement in leaking classified documents to her while he was posted as officer on special duty at the PMO between July 1997 and April 1998. Sharma and Bhatnagar were allegedly romantically involved during the time. The quantum of sentence to be announced can range from life imprisonment to the death penalty for the guilty.

by Rahul Tewari

Virtual Suicide for Love

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM In a bizarre twist of fate, a dental college student in Kannur turned his webcam towards the ceiling and hung himself from the fan in his hostel room even as his stunned girlfriend watched in horror. V.S. Karthik, 21, was a third-year student at the Pariyaram Medical College. He was reportedly in love with a girl he

was related to. She is a management student in Delhi and was chatting with him online when Karthik took the extreme step. She was wailing and pleading with him not to take the step but to no avail. Incidentally, Kerala tops India in suicides (26.8 per lakh population as against national average of 10.5).

by M.G. Radhakrishnan